

PLAIN ENGLISH AI GUIDE

AI Without The Tech Nonsense

Finally understand where to start with AI, what to ask it, and how to use it confidently in everyday life.

A calm, practical guide that shows you where AI fits, gives you useful messages to start with, and helps you put it into practice without technical confusion.

Welcome

AI is everywhere, but that does not mean it has been explained in a useful way.

If you have wondered what AI could actually help you with, where to begin, or what you are supposed to type, the confusion is understandable. Most explanations begin with technical terms, dramatic claims, or a long list of tools. None of that gives you a practical starting point.

This guide does. You will start with one tool, use ready-to-type messages on ordinary tasks, learn how to shape better requests, and then practise until using AI begins to feel familiar.

What you will be able to do

Recognise where AI can make everyday tasks easier, know what to ask, improve the answer, and use the result with confidence.

What you will not need

Technical knowledge, special software skills, clever prompt tricks, or an understanding of how AI is built.

The goal is not to make you an AI expert. It is to make AI understandable and usable enough that you can open it with a real task in mind and know what to do next.

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1. AI, Explained Simply

AI can sound like a large and technical subject. For everyday use, you only need to understand one simple idea.

When you type a message into ChatGPT, it produces a response using patterns it learned from a very large amount of writing. It has seen the shapes of explanations, emails, lists, plans and conversations, so it can create something similar for the job you give it.

That is why it can turn a rough message into a clearer one, shorten a long letter, arrange scattered notes or explain unfamiliar words. It recognises the kind of response that would usually be useful and builds one for you.

A FAMILIAR EXAMPLE

Imagine asking for help with a polite reply

You have received an email and know roughly what you want to say, but you are unsure how to phrase it. ChatGPT has seen countless examples of polite replies. When you give it your main points, it can use those patterns to produce a clear draft.

It has not met the person receiving your email. It does not know whether every detail is correct. It is helping with the wording. You still decide whether the reply says what you mean.

Why it can be useful and still be wrong

ChatGPT is very good at producing an answer that sounds natural. That is not the same as automatically knowing the truth. If you ask it to rewrite words you provide, you can judge the result yourself. If you ask it for a date, price, rule or fact, the answer may need checking.

This is not a contradiction. It is simply the difference between using AI to *help create something* and relying on it to *know something important*.

Ask it to help create

Writing, rewriting, summarising, organising and planning are natural starting points because you can see whether the result helps.

Ask it to help you think

It can arrange pros and cons, suggest questions or turn a muddled thought into something easier to consider.

Guide the answer

Tell it what you need, read the result and ask for a change. Using AI is a conversation, not a one-time command.

Keep the final say

AI provides material for you to use. Your knowledge of your own life, needs and intentions still matters most.

Why it has felt harder than it should

AI arrived through headlines, new buttons and unfamiliar language before most people were shown its practical purpose. You have not failed to understand it. You were rarely given a clear explanation and a sensible place to begin.

If you remember one thing: AI is not a technical subject you must master before using it. It is a tool you can give ordinary jobs to, then judge and improve the result.

2. Where To Start

The number of AI tools can make starting feel like a decision in itself. It does not need to be.

Start with ChatGPT. It is a straightforward place to learn because you can type to it in normal language. You do not need to choose special settings or know the correct terminology. If you can write a message, you can begin.

Other tools may be worth exploring later, but comparing all of them now creates a question you do not yet need to answer. First learn what it feels like to ask one tool for help and shape the response.

1

Open ChatGPT

Go to chatgpt.com or use the official ChatGPT app.

2

Find the message box

This is where you type a question or instruction, just as you would type a message to someone.

3

Give it one ordinary job

Choose a real task that would be helpful today. The next section gives you three easy options.

4

Read and respond

If the answer is not quite right, tell it what to change. You do not need to begin again.

What is a prompt?

A prompt is simply the message you type into AI. It can be as short as "Explain this in plain English" or as specific as "Rewrite this email so it sounds clear, polite and friendly." In this guide, we call them messages because that is exactly what they are.

WHAT THE FIRST CONVERSATION FEELS LIKE

You type a message and press Enter. ChatGPT replies underneath it. If the answer is useful, you can copy it, adapt it or simply use it to think. If it is not right, type another message below it such as, "Make this shorter" or, "Explain that more simply." ChatGPT remembers the conversation above, so you can continue without repeating everything.

There is no test to pass and no perfect wording required. You are allowed to begin with an ordinary sentence and improve the request as you go.

For now: one tool, one real task and one useful conversation are enough.

3. Use It For The First Time

The easiest way to understand AI is to watch it help with something familiar. We will begin with a message that needs rewriting.

THE SITUATION

You know what you want to say, but not quite how to say it

Imagine you need to contact a company about a delivery that has not arrived. You want to be firm, but you do not want the message to sound angry. Your rough version says:

My order was meant to arrive three days ago and it still is not here. I need to know what is happening because I cannot keep waiting around for it.

The meaning is clear. The only difficult part is turning it into a message you feel comfortable sending.

Step 1: give ChatGPT the job

Type this message

Rewrite the message below so it sounds clear, polite and firm. Keep the meaning the same.

My order was meant to arrive three days ago and it still is not here. I need to know what is happening because I cannot keep waiting around for it.

STEP 2

Read the first answer

ChatGPT might reply with something like this:

Hello, my order was due to arrive three days ago, but it has still not been delivered. Could you please confirm its current status and let me know when I can expect it? I would appreciate an update as soon as possible.

The answer is clearer and more measured. But perhaps it feels slightly more formal than the way you normally write. You do not have to accept it as it is.

Step 3: ask for one change

Follow up with

Make it sound a little more natural and less formal, while keeping it firm.

ChatGPT now has the earlier message and its first answer in the conversation. It can adjust the wording without you explaining the whole situation again.

Hi, my order was due three days ago but it still has not arrived. Could you let me know what is happening and when I should expect it? I would really appreciate an update soon.

What you have just learned

You gave AI a clear job, judged the result and asked for a change. You did not need a clever command or technical knowledge. The useful skill was knowing what you wanted and being willing to guide the answer.

Two more useful first tasks

Shorten something long

Use this when you want the important points without working through every word.

Ready-to-use message

Summarise the text below into three clear bullet points. Then tell me whether there is anything I need to do next.

[Paste the text here]

Compare two choices

Use this when two products, services or plans feel difficult to compare.

Ready-to-use message

Compare these two options in plain English. Show me the main difference, the advantages of each and which looks better for my needs.

My needs: [say what matters]

Option 1: [paste it here]

Option 2: [paste it here]

The basic rhythm is always the same: choose a job, ask in normal language, read the answer and improve it if needed.

4. Where AI Fits Into Everyday Life

The question is not, "What can AI do?" The more useful question is, "Where could it make something in my own life easier?"

You do not need to invent special AI projects. Look at the ordinary things that already take more thought, time or patience than they should. Most useful everyday tasks fall into three simple groups: understanding something, communicating something or organising something.

The ten examples in this section are numbered in the order you will meet them. Start with the group that sounds most like the kind of help you want.

A simple way to notice an opportunity

If you find yourself thinking, "I wish this were clearer," "I am not sure how to word this," or, "I do not know where to begin," there may be a sensible job for AI.

Help me understand something

Long letters, unfamiliar terms and official wording can be tiring even when the subject itself is not complicated. AI can give you a simpler first explanation so you know what you are looking at and what questions you may need to ask.

EVERYDAY SITUATION

You receive a long letter about a change to a service. The important information is somewhere inside it, but the wording makes it difficult to see what has changed and whether you need to respond. Asking AI for the main points can give you a clearer route into the original letter. You still keep the letter and check anything important against it.

1. Understand something long

Find the main point and any action you need to take.

Type this

Explain this in plain English. Give me the three most important points and tell me what, if anything, I need to do next.

[Paste the text]

2. Make sense of forms and admin

Understand what a form or letter is asking and prepare your reply.

Type this

Explain what this is asking me to do in plain English. Make a checklist of the information I need. Do not invent any missing details.

[Paste the wording]

3. Remove unfamiliar language

Translate technical or specialist wording into normal language.

Type this

Explain this in plain English for someone who is new to the subject. Avoid jargon and give one everyday example.

[Paste the wording]

Help me communicate something

Often, you already know what you mean. The effort lies in finding the right words, choosing the right tone or turning several rough points into one clear message. AI can help with the expression while you remain responsible for the meaning.

EVERYDAY SITUATION

You want to decline an invitation without sounding cold. You could tell ChatGPT who the message is for, why you cannot attend and how you want it to sound. The result is not a message from AI instead of you. It is a draft made from the meaning you supplied, which you can then adjust until it feels like yours.

4. Write a clear email

Turn rough points into a message that sounds like you.

Type this

Write a clear, friendly email using the points below. Keep it natural and under 150 words.

Who it is for: [person]

What I need to say: [points]

5. Get the tone right

Make a message warmer, firmer or more natural.

Type this

Rewrite this so it sounds [warm / polite / firm / reassuring]. Keep my meaning and make it sound like a real person wrote it.

[Paste the message]

Help me organise something

Some jobs are difficult because there are too many loose pieces: choices to compare, steps to remember or ideas that have not yet become a plan. AI can give those pieces a useful shape. It does not need to make the decision for you.

EVERYDAY SITUATION

You want to plan several evening meals using food you already have. Instead of staring at the cupboard and beginning from nothing, you can list the ingredients, explain how many people you are feeding and ask for a simple plan. You can then reject anything unsuitable and ask for alternatives.

6. Compare before buying

See the differences that matter without getting lost in sales language.

Type this

Compare these options for someone who cares most about [price / simplicity / quality]. Use a short table and explain which looks better for that need.

[Paste the options]

7. Make a practical plan

Turn a loose idea into manageable steps.

Type this

Help me make a simple plan for [task or event]. Ask me up to three questions first, then give me a short step-by-step plan and a checklist.

8. Think through a decision

Organise your thoughts without handing over the decision.

Type this

Help me think through this decision without choosing for me. Show me the main pros, cons and questions I should consider.

The decision: [describe it]

9. Organise rough notes

Turn scattered thoughts into something you can use.

Type this

Organise these rough notes into clear headings and bullet points. Keep every important detail but remove repetition.

[Paste your notes]

10. Get unstuck

Replace a blank page with a useful first draft.

Type this

I need to start [task], but I am not sure how. Ask me three simple questions, then create a rough first draft or starting plan I can improve.

Choose usefulness over novelty

You do not need to use every example. Notice the two or three situations that resemble your own life. Confidence usually begins when AI becomes dependable for a few ordinary jobs, not when you try to use it for everything.

5. How To Ask For What You Need

You do not need special prompt skills. You only need to give AI enough information to understand the job.

Imagine asking another person for help. "Help me with this" leaves them guessing. A few useful details make the request easier to understand. ChatGPT works in much the same way.

A useful request normally answers four ordinary questions. You will not need every part every time, but they give you somewhere dependable to start.

1

What is the job?

Do you want AI to explain, write, shorten, compare, organise, plan or help you begin?

2

What does it need to know?

Add only the context that changes the answer: who it is for, what matters or what you have already tried.

3

What should the answer look like?

Ask for bullet points, a short message, a table, a checklist or step-by-step instructions.

4

How should it sound?

Say whether you want it simple, friendly, direct, reassuring, short or detailed.

The What To Ask Builder

Fill in the gaps

Help me [job].

This is for [person or purpose].

The important details are [context].

Give me the answer as [format], and make it [tone and length].

BEFORE YOU USE THE BUILDER

What do the square brackets mean?

Whenever you see words inside square brackets, such as **[job]** or **[person]**, they show you where to add your own details.

Delete the words inside the brackets, remove the brackets themselves, and replace them with information about your situation.

- Do not type the square brackets. Replace the whole bracketed section with your own words.
- Your answer can be short and simple. You do not need to find the perfect wording.
- If a bracketed part does not apply to your situation, you can leave that sentence out.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Here is what the completed builder can look like

Help me write an email asking my energy supplier to explain an unexpected increase in my bill.

This is for the customer service team.

The important details are that my bill has increased from £85 to £132, my usage has not noticeably changed, and I want them to check whether the bill is correct.

Give me the answer as a short email, and make it polite, clear and firm, using no more than 150 words.

The request is useful because it explains the job, who the answer is for, the details that matter and what the finished answer should look like.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2

Ask for help planning without knowing every detail

Sometimes you cannot provide all the context because you are still working out what matters. In that case, ask ChatGPT to question you first.

Help me plan a small family lunch. I have not decided the menu or timings yet.

Ask me up to five simple questions, one at a time, then make a plan and shopping list from my answers.

This removes the pressure to build a perfect request before you begin. The conversation itself helps you clarify the task.

Improve the answer without starting again

The first answer is often useful but not quite right. This is normal. You are not correcting a mistake in how you used AI; you are giving it the extra direction that becomes obvious once

you can see a draft.

Too long?

"Keep the useful points but make this half as long."

Too vague?

"Make this more practical and give me specific next steps."

Wrong tone?

"Make this warmer and more natural without becoming over-friendly."

Not quite you?

"Keep the meaning, but use simpler words and make it sound more like an everyday conversation."

Missing something?

"Before you rewrite this, ask me any questions you need to fill the gaps."

Unsure?

"Tell me which parts are certain, which are assumptions and what I may need to check."

The part that builds confidence

Confident AI use does not mean producing a perfect first request. It means knowing that you can begin in ordinary language, judge the result and guide the conversation until it becomes useful.

6. Your 7-Day Confidence Plan

Reading creates understanding. A few small experiences turn that understanding into something you can rely on.

This plan is not a course you have to keep up with. Each day asks you to use AI on something that already exists in your life. If you miss a day, continue when it suits you. Nothing is lost.

What counts as success?

Success is not using AI every day forever. It is reaching the point where, when a suitable task appears, you recognise that AI could help and know what to type.

Choose how you want to begin each day

If you already know what you want to ask, try writing the message in your own words first. There is no single correct way to phrase it.

If you would prefer a starting point, copy the ready-to-use message provided for that day and replace anything inside square brackets with your own details.

Days 1 and 2: become comfortable asking

1

Make something clearer

Why: rewriting is easy to judge because you already know the meaning.

Try it yourself: ask AI to rewrite a real message in the way you want it to sound.

Or use this starting message

Rewrite the message below so it sounds clear, polite and natural. Keep my meaning the same.

[Paste your message]

Notice: you remain in control of what is finally sent.

2

Make something shorter

Why: summarising shows how AI can reduce reading effort.

Try it yourself: ask for the main points from something you already need to read.

Or use this starting message

Summarise the text below into three clear bullet points. Then tell me whether there is anything I need to do next.

[Paste the text]

Notice: use the summary as a guide into the original, not a replacement when details matter.

Days 3 and 4: use AI to understand and think

3

Make something easier to understand

Why: unfamiliar language often makes a simple subject feel difficult.

Try it yourself: ask AI to explain a paragraph in language that feels clearer to you.

Or use this starting message

Explain the text below in plain English. Avoid jargon and give me one everyday example.

[Paste the text]

Notice: ask a follow-up about any part that remains unclear.

4

Make a choice clearer

Why: AI can organise a decision without making it for you.

Try it yourself: describe two ordinary options and say what matters most to you.

Or use this starting message

Compare the two options below. Show me the main advantages and disadvantages of each. Do not choose for me.

What matters to me: [say what matters]

Option 1: [paste it here]

Option 2: [paste it here]

Notice: personal context makes the comparison more useful.

Days 5 and 6: make AI fit your life

5

Turn a loose idea into a plan

Why: beginning is often harder than doing.

Try it yourself: ask for help planning meals, a visit, a household task or something you have postponed.

Or use this starting message

Help me make a simple plan for [task]. Ask me up to three questions first, then give me manageable steps and a checklist.

Notice: remove anything unrealistic and ask for a simpler version if needed.

6

Choose your own useful task

Why: confidence grows when the task is genuinely yours.

Try it yourself: notice one moment of confusion, wording difficulty or mental clutter and give AI that job.

If you are not sure where to begin

Help me find one useful way AI could make an everyday task easier. Ask me three simple questions about what I need to do today, then suggest one small task we can work on together.

Notice: which part of the task became easier?

DAY 7

Choose the uses worth keeping

Look back at the week. Which two or three tasks produced something genuinely useful? Save the messages you used somewhere easy to find.

You may discover that AI is especially helpful for understanding letters, writing replies or turning ideas into plans. Someone else may choose different uses. The point is not to use AI everywhere. It is to know where it earns a place in your own life.

Try it yourself: write down the tasks that helped and decide which ones you would genuinely use again.

Or use this reflection message

I used AI for the tasks below this week. Help me identify the two or three most useful ways I could continue using it. Keep the answer practical and do not suggest extra uses unless they closely match what already helped.

[List the tasks you tried]

By the end of the week, you have not merely read about AI. You have built a small collection of experiences that show you where it helps, what to ask and how to improve the result.

7. Use AI With Good Judgement

Confidence does not mean trusting every answer. It means understanding what kind of help you are receiving and knowing when a check is worthwhile.

Most of the tasks in this guide are low risk. If AI helps rewrite an email or organise a shopping list, you can read the result and decide whether it works. You are judging something familiar.

Facts and advice are different. A date, price, rule or medical statement can sound perfectly clear and still be mistaken or out of date. In those situations, the sensible next step is to check the important detail with an appropriate source.

THE USEFUL DISTINCTION

Am I asking for help creating, or help knowing?

If you ask AI to make your own words clearer, you can usually judge the draft yourself. If you ask what a contract means, when a payment is due or what a symptom could indicate, the answer may help you form questions, but the important information should be confirmed elsewhere.

This one distinction removes much of the uncertainty. You do not need to become suspicious of every answer. You only need to recognise when being wrong would matter.

Treat drafts as drafts

For writing, organising and brainstorming, read the result and adjust it until it suits you.

Check facts that matter

Confirm important prices, dates, names, rules or claims with an official or reliable source.

Keep private details private

Do not paste passwords, bank details, private identification numbers or information you would not want shared.

Keep people involved

For medical, legal, financial or safety decisions, use the appropriate professional or official source.

The three-question check

- Did it answer what I actually asked?
- Is this a draft I can judge myself, or a factual claim that needs checking?
- Would a mistake here have a meaningful consequence?

Useful checking message

Review your last answer. Separate what is well supported from what may be an assumption, and list anything I should verify before using it.

Good judgement is part of confident use. It allows you to enjoy the convenience of AI on ordinary tasks without handing it responsibility that still belongs with you, an official source or an appropriate professional.

8. Quick Reference

If you forget everything else, return to this page.

Where to start

Open ChatGPT and give it one ordinary job you already need to do.

What to ask

Say what the job is, give useful context, choose the format and describe the tone.

What to do next

Read the answer and ask for a specific change. The first response is not the final response.

What to check

Verify important facts and keep private or high-stakes matters outside ordinary AI use.

Your all-purpose starting message

Copy and complete this

Help me [job]. This is for [purpose]. The important details are [context]. Give me the answer as [format] and make it [tone and length]. If you need more information, ask me up to three questions first.

Your all-purpose improvement message

Copy this

Keep what is useful, but make the answer clearer, more practical and easier to use. Ask me a question if anything important is missing.

OPTIONAL REFERENCE A

Other AI Tools

You do not need these to complete the guide. They are here for later, once using ChatGPT feels normal.

Claude

Often useful for reading and working with long documents. Official site: claude.ai.

Gemini

Convenient if you already use Google products. Official site: gemini.google.com.

Perplexity

Useful for web answers that include links to sources. Official site: perplexity.ai.

Extra ChatGPT tools

Search is useful for current information, image creation for visuals and deep research for larger questions. Explore these only when you have a reason to use them.

The best tool is not the one with the longest feature list. It is the one you can give a useful job to. One familiar tool is enough to begin.

OPTIONAL REFERENCE B

Checking Suspicious Content

You do not need to identify every fake by sight. You need a few dependable ways to pause and check before believing, clicking or sharing.

Email

Check the actual sender address. Avoid links or requests for passwords, payment or urgent action. Visit the organisation through its official website instead.

Social messages

Check whether the account is genuine. If someone asks for money or creates urgency, contact the person another way before responding.

Photos

Use Google Lens or a reverse image search to find where the image appeared before. Treat AI detectors only as an extra clue, not proof.

News and claims

Look for the same claim on reliable news sites or an official source. A single post is not confirmation.

Message for checking a claim

Search the web for reliable sources about the claim below. Tell me what is confirmed, what remains uncertain and where the information comes from.

[Paste the claim]

You Now Have A Clear Way To Keep Using AI

AI may not feel completely familiar yet, and it does not need to. Familiarity comes from using it when a real need appears.

You now understand the basic idea behind AI, why it can be useful and why some answers need checking. You know where to begin, how to recognise a suitable everyday task and how to ask for an answer you can actually use.

More importantly, you know that the first answer does not have to be perfect. You can ask for a change, add a missing detail or tell ChatGPT to explain something differently. That simple back-and-forth is where much of the value comes from.

- ✓ You understand what AI is and why it can help with ordinary tasks.
- ✓ You know where to start without comparing every available tool.
- ✓ You can recognise useful places for AI in everyday life.
- ✓ You have ready-to-use messages for ten common situations.
- ✓ You can build your own request and improve an answer that misses the mark.
- ✓ You can use AI repeatedly through the 7-day confidence plan.
- ✓ You know when your own judgement is enough and when something needs checking.

Your next step

Choose one real task, open ChatGPT and use the message that fits. It can be a reply you need to write, something you want explained or a plan you have not yet started.

Confident AI use does not begin with knowing everything. It begins with understanding enough to know what to do next. You now have that starting point.